



The remains of a colonnaded street (*cardo maximus*) at Apamea in Syria are 475 feet (145 m) long. The street would have been lined along both sides with buildings for public use.

By 27 BCE Octavian was, in effect, the empire's first "Emperor," taking the title Augustus (see pp.112). The Romans themselves did not consider that the republic ended with Caesar's death, and when Augustus came to power he did not paint himself as an all-powerful emperor figure. Instead, he claimed to have restored the republic and to have returned power to the Senate and the people. Augustus represented himself as "first among equals" with his fellow senators, although, in reality, he held supreme power.

The empire of Augustus started out with republican pretensions (rule by the Senate and Roman people), but while Augustus retained parts of the existing system, he grafted his own autocracy onto it. The republic's system of rule, based on competition among aristocratic families, was replaced by an imperial one in which a single aristocratic family dominated.

A worldwide empire

By the late 1st century CE, and the time of the emperor Trajan (ruled 98–117 CE), Rome headed an empire

praetors, who ruled in the emperor's name. By the 3rd century CE, separate leaders often attended to military matters. Within these provinces, cities looked much like Roman ones and were run according to a Roman-style system of law. One key feature of the 2nd-century empire was the rising status of these provinces and their great cities—for example, Ephesus in Asia Minor and Leptis Magna in North Africa (see map, left).

The urban centers of imperial Rome were linked by an impressive transport and communication network made

From Republic to Empire

As the structures of the republican system gave way to the empire, Rome found itself in command of vast, worldwide territories. The empire encompassed a diverse mix of peoples, and its politics, way of life, artistic achievements, and spectacular feats of engineering have had a lasting impact.



The Library of Celsus at Ephesus (Turkey) was built in the 2nd century CE as a monument to a Roman senator and governor. It stored thousands of manuscripts in scrolls. The front of the building has been faithfully restored.

of great wealth, which stretched across a vast area that took in all of the Mediterranean, the Middle East, and a large chunk of northern and central Europe. In the first two centuries of imperial rule, there were probably around 50 million people living in Roman lands.

The bulk of these lands were conquered during the days of the republic. The empire consolidated these areas and added a few new provinces, although these new acquisitions were also the first to be given up later on. Britain, Dacia (modern Romania), Assyria, and Mesopotamia (Iraq) were short-lived gains compared to other territories. Roman rulers were quick to crush any rebellion or threat (from outside or from within), often brutally. This is one reason why the empire was relatively stable during this time.

The expansion that was achieved was greatly helped by the work of emperors such as Trajan and Claudius. Another major factor in maintaining these lands was the Romans' legendary military might. Crucially, the empire had a standing army, unlike during much of the republic. Its soldiers were a professional, highly organized, and skilled machine, and loyal to the emperor (see pp.114–15).

An urban civilization

Ancient Roman civilization was highly urbanized, with a vast network of prosperous cities, filled with beautiful buildings that usually mirrored the city of Rome itself, such as temples and a public forum. The empire's extensive territories were divided into provinces ruled by governors called proconsuls or

possible by the Romans' unique talent for engineering—new roads, bridges, viaducts, harbors, and aqueducts were built throughout the empire.

"Warehouse of the world"

Good communication links also aided the empire's trade, although the road system often proved slow and Roman trade came into its own much more through the use of maritime transport. Rome's huge empire meant that it had at its command a

INVENTION

THE ROAD SYSTEM

The empire was connected by thousands of miles of expertly made roads, typically consisting of stone slabs laid over rubble. Vital for allowing soldiers to move around as fast as possible—which is why Roman roads are often straight—they helped to control the vast territories. Much of the network in Italy centered on Rome, hence the proverb "All roads lead to Rome." Many Roman roads survive today, some in good condition—such as the Appian Way in Rome (below) which linked Rome with southeastern Italy.

